

Chapter

I Know, Yet I Don't Do — When Knowledge Doesn't Work



Introduction: Why Do We Falter Even When We Know?

Many of us know what is right and what is wrong. We have read scriptures, listened to discourses, even gone to a Guru. And yet we keep repeating the same mistakes in life. Why does this happen? In this short discourse, Acharya Upendra Ji opens up this very question with the help of two verses from the third chapter of the Shrimad Bhagavad Gita — and in the

characters of the Mahabharata he shows us a picture of our own mind, intellect and inner distortions.

All Beings Are Driven by Their Nature

Acharya Ji begins with the very first word of the verse — what does "prani" (living being) mean:

"What should we understand by prani? Arre, we are not talking about dogs and cats. One who has prana within is a prani. So we too are prani. It doesn't say animal, it says living being."

**sadrśaṁ ceṣṭate svasyāḥ prakṛter jñānavān api
prakṛtiṁ yānti bhūtāni nigrahaḥ kiṁ kariṣyati**

"All beings follow their nature, that is, they act under the sway of their own disposition. Even the man of knowledge acts according to his own nature; what then can anyone's forcing do?"

— Bhagavad Gita 3.33

Acharya Ji explains the word "svabhav" (nature) by breaking it into two parts:

"**Sva** means I myself, **bhav** means your emotions. So it is something about the mind. Being under the sway of one's own mind, under the sway of one's own nature, one performs actions."

This is nothing unusual — we see it every day:

"We say, don't we, the five fingers are not the same. People talk in different ways, behave differently, work with different qualities. So everyone acts under the sway of their own nature. There is nothing big in this."

Knowledge Does Not Stop One from Sinning

The real sting of the verse lies in its second part — **even the man of knowledge** goes by his own nature. Acharya Ji clarifies what kind of knowledge is meant here:

"Now this is not tattvagyan; that will come in the eighteenth chapter. This is just normal — read books, read many books, read scriptures, read mantras, did all the sadhana there was to do, even became a gyani, became Pandit Ji."

Tattvagyan — knowledge of the truth born of direct experience; not merely knowledge that has been read or heard.

Even such a person acts according to his own nature:

"He also works according to — whatever his original destiny was, such is his nature."

And Acharya Ji puts the essence of the whole verse in one direct sentence:

"It is said to him in simple words: **knowledge will not stop you from sinning. Knowledge does not stop one from sinning.**"

Krishna First Tried to Teach Duryodhan

Acharya Ji connects this truth to an episode from the Mahabharata:

"Krishna had first told the Gita to Duryodhan, do you know? He told it to Arjun later. First Krishna had tried to tell Duryodhan, had tried to tell Dhritarashtra first, do you know? They did not understand."

There is a rule behind this:

"There is always a rule — a bad person should be taught such a scripture first, so that he does not commit the evil in the first place. If he never did it, there would be no war at all."

But that is not what happened:

"But a bad man is bad, he will not stop — and he did not stop."

So the teaching then becomes necessary for the good person. Acharya Ji explains that the Gita does not teach only

endurance:

"That is why the good man also has to learn that I may sometimes have to strike back at him. So will I only have to endure? Enduring was spoken of in the second chapter. After that it doesn't just say 'endure' — **you have to counter something.**"

"Don't Give Me Gyan": Duryodhan's Real Problem

When Krishna went to explain, what answer did he get? Acharya Ji puts it in today's language:

"They said just this much: 'Don't give me gyan.' Just like college boys say these days — when you go to teach them something — 'Don't give gyan, we have enough knowledge.'"

"Especially in cities, children talk this way. I don't know, maybe the same language will reach the villages too — 'Don't give me gyan, I know.'"

And truly, Duryodhan did not lack knowledge:

"So didn't Duryodhan have knowledge? He went to the gurukul, the same — he must have gone to Arjun's gurukul, the same."

His problem was something else entirely, and he admitted it himself:

"Duryodhan had said, 'What is right and what is wrong, I understand that too. My problem is something else.'
He says, '**Dharma I do know, but I have no desire to do it. And adharma too I know, what it is, but I cannot give it up.** If you have some cure for this, then tell me.'"

This sentiment of Duryodhan is found in the tradition as a well-known verse:

jānāmi dharmam na ca me pravṛttiḥ

jānāmy adharmaṁ na ca me nivṛttiḥ

"I know dharma, yet I have no inclination towards it; I know adharma, yet I cannot turn away from it."

— Pandava Gita (Prapanna Gita)

And Acharya Ji turns this straight back on us:

"So his problem is understood. **This is our problem too**
— within us too a Duryodhan, a Dhritarashtra lies
hidden."

The Mahabharata Within Us

From here Acharya Ji opens up the characters of the Mahabharata not as people outside, but as symbols of forces within.

Dhritarashtra — the Blind Mind

"So Dhritarashtra is basically — he is blind, isn't he — so he is the symbol of our mind. It is our mind. Mind is actually blind, meaning it gets stuck in maya. It is blind, it is not wise."

Gandhari — the Intellect That Blindfolded Itself

"Whom was he married to? Gandhari. Did Gandhari have eyes or not? Yes. She is the symbol of the intellect."

The intellect's job was to show the mind the way, but it did the opposite:

"The intellect is supposed to be higher; it should have shown him the way. The wife of a blind man — if she were a truly devoted wife, should she have tied on a blindfold, or should she rather have guided him her whole life?"

"So our intellect becomes blind, it too goes blind knowingly, when you act completely subservient to the mind, subservient to your nature."

The Kauravas — a Hundred Distortions

What will be the offspring of a blind mind and an intellect that has bound its own eyes? Acharya Ji explains with arithmetic:

"And its result will be the Kauravas, meaning a hundred. So our ten senses — in total five karmendriyas and five gyanendriyas, five and five make ten — say ten distortions for each, so ten times ten is a hundred. **A hundred distortions.**"

Karmendriyas — the five organs of action (speech, hands, feet, organ of procreation, organ of excretion); **gyanendriyas** — the five organs of knowledge (eyes, ears, nose, tongue, skin).

Duryodhan and Dushasan: The Meaning Hidden in the Names

Acharya Ji also opens up the meaning of the two most prominent names among the Kauravas:

"So like Duryodhan — one who stays far from wealth. Far from wealth does not mean the wealth of money — divine wealth. **Compassion, forgiveness, love — that's called daivi sampatti, divine wealth.** The person who stays very far from it is Duryodhan."

"Dushasan — one who cannot govern properly."

And then the decisive point:

"These are all not persons outside; **they are qualities, each one within us.**"

This is the very reason problems come into most people's lives:

"This is the reason problems come to so many people: **they know knowledge, but there is no desire to do it.** Even after going to the Guru, they do not do what is right."

The Solution: Do Not Come Under the Sway of Attraction and Aversion

So what is the remedy? Acharya Ji says the solution lies right after the same verse:

"So see the solution further on in the Bhagavad Gita — right after the same verse, verse 34 says what Duryodhan could not understand, what Dhritarashtra could not understand in his delusion, but Arjun understood."

**indriyasyendriyasyārthe rāga-dveṣau
vyavasthitau
tayo na vaśam āgacchet tau hy asya
paripanthinau**

"In the objects of each and every sense, attraction and aversion lie hidden. One should not come under the sway of these two, for both of them are great enemies obstructing one's path to well-being."

— Bhagavad Gita 3.34

Acharya Ji gives "the objects of the senses" a practical form:

"Indriya means our whole body, the sense organs. In the objects of each sense means whatever we interact with the world — whatever we are connected with, whatever it is happening with: object, person, place — in it attraction and aversion lie hidden."

And the meaning of raga and dvesha:

"Raga-dvesha means **likes and dislikes, what we like and what we don't**. For everyone — I like this food, I don't like that. I want to marry this type — I like this woman, not that one."

"So won't everyone's likes and dislikes be different? Every person's likes and dislikes will be different."

The Gita's instruction is not to come under the sway of these two:

"Just because you like something, that is not why you do it; just because you don't like it, that is not why you don't do it — it's not like that."

Shreya and Preya

So if not by likes and dislikes, then on what basis should we act? Acharya Ji answers:

"So what should one do then? What would the whole of the rest of the Bhagavad Gita have said? **What the Guru says — what is right and what is wrong.**"

This is what the scriptures call **shreya** and **preya**:

"Shreya means the excellent action, the action the Guru has told. Preya means what feels dear to me."

"So I must not sit doing things just because 'I feel like it.' **The scriptures themselves should become dear to me.**"

This is the cure for Duryodhan's problem — when shreya itself becomes preya, the desire to do the dharma we already know also awakens.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 All beings act under the sway of their own nature — **sva** (I) and **bhav** (emotions); that is, under the sway of the mind.
- 2 Knowledge that is read or heard is not enough — **knowledge does not stop one from sinning**; even the man of knowledge goes by his own nature.
- 3 Krishna first tried to make Duryodhan and Dhritarashtra understand; the bad man did not stop, so the good man has to learn not only to endure but **to counter as well**.
- 4 Duryodhan's problem was not ignorance — **"I know dharma but have no desire to do it; I know adharma but cannot give it up."** This is our problem too.

- 5 **Dhritarashtra** is the **blind mind**, **Gandhari** is the **intellect** that, subservient to the mind, knowingly goes blind, and the **hundred Kauravas** are the hundred distortions of the ten senses.
- 6 **Duryodhan** is one who is far from divine wealth such as compassion, forgiveness and love; **Dushasan** is one who cannot govern properly — these are not people outside but **qualities within**.
- 7 In the object of every sense **raga-dvesha (likes and dislikes)** lie hidden; they are great enemies on the path to well-being, and one should not come under their sway.
- 8 The basis of action should be **shreya** (the excellent action told by the Guru), not **preya** (what feels dear to me) — **the scriptures themselves should become dear to me**.